

Gathering Information - System Design

When gathering information AKA *"fact finding"* you normally go about in a couple common ways.

- Interviews, Questionnaires, *"Comment Cards"*, I/O forms, Observe activity, Research existing solutions.

You should try to **effectively engage** in all of these ways of getting facts (to then make diagrams, or understand what you're creating) *to try to get the most out of them.*

Interviews: Try to ask 4 distinct types of questions; open-ended, closed, probing, contextual

- But how do I actually do that?
 - **Open Ended:** You want your questions to be *"How, Why, Walk me through, Tell me about, Describe."* These are normally the **first questions** you ask when starting an interview, tend to be **general**.
 - *"What happens when [situation occurs]?"*
 - *"Walk me through [process] from start to finish."*
 - **Probing:** Normally follow a point in the story they are giving you *after the open ended question* that should be interesting.
 - *"You mentioned fines are tricky, why?"*
 - *"What causes fines to be tricky?"*
 - *"What frustrates you with the current solution?" (Important one)*
 - **Contextual:** You bring up a certain case scenario, **specific event** that would actually happen, and ask them to run you through it.
 - *"Can you run me through how you would train a new librarian?"*
 - *"Walk me through the last return you processed."*
 - **Close Ended:** Simply, sometimes you might need a quick yes or no answer or a quick number/statement answer.
 - *"How long does it take to submit a book?"*
 - *"Are you currently able to automatically handle fines?"*
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All of these culminate into a successful interview. After which you send out **COMMENT CARDS**.

Comment Cards: After you finish your interview, you want to ensure; you *correctly understood* what the interviewee was trying to say, allows the **interviewee to contact you** if they remember something and *captures follow up questions*.

So you **send out cards** for the *interviewee to send back if they can remember anything*.

- *Cards tend to look like below.*

Date: _____

Interviewee: _____ **Role:** _____

KEY POINTS (*from our conversation*):

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

CONTACT (Interviewer):

Name: _____ **Email:** _____

Please return by: _____

Did we miss anything? _____

Questionnaires: These *attempt to solve the same problem as the interview*, but are for the entire user base of the client. It's **mass data**.

- **Quantitative:** (Questions should be about How many, Rate this system, *Answers would be rankings, scalar*)
 - *How many checkouts do you process daily?* _____
 - *Rate current system ease of use (1=difficult, 5=easy):* 1 2 3 4 5
 - **Qualitative:** (Questions should be open-ended just like the interview, *answers should be short sentences.*)
 - *What is the biggest problem with the current system?*
 - *What feature would help you most?*
 - **Open:** (There should just be one free question, for **general information capture**)
 - *Anything you would like for us to know?*
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The last general tool for information gathering is “**I/O forms**” (Input, Output) This is looking at the EXISTING system, (or other people’s existing systems)

- **Input:** On digital forms, or paper forms; *What variables are there? Which ones need to be on there but aren’t, what issues plague this input version?*
- **Output:** On the output, be it physical or digital, ask the same questions, *What variables are there? Which ones need to be on there but aren’t, what issues plague this input version?*

What this culminates in, is the *most accurate and viable tool for what the system needs to be able to do.*

- **Input:** Paper form has first name, last name, Age, and address; the Email is missing.
 - **Output:** The full name gets cut off.
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These are the **KEY** tools that you use to create the system and further hone it to match what the client truly wants.